Lesson 18: Effective Paragraphs

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 3: Paragraphs, Essays and Cohesion

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 3.1: Effective Means for Writing a Paragraph.

In this lesson

You will study the three parts of an effective paragraph (topic sentence, body and concluding sentence) and the transitions that join them, analyse the book's model paragraphs and write a paragraph of your own. University essays, exam answers and psychology reports are built from such paragraphs, and this paragraph is the first step towards your Unit 3 essay.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Identify the main idea and the controlling idea in a topic sentence.
- Evaluate topic sentences with the book's five characteristics of a good topic sentence.
- Identify the topic sentence, supporting sentences and concluding sentence in a paragraph.
- Write supporting sentences of different types and a concluding sentence that restates the main point in new words.
- Link ideas with transitional words and phrases.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
topic sentence	the sentence that states the paragraph's main idea and the writer's attitude to it	Most forms of writing can be improved by first creating an outline.
main idea	the subject or topic the writer is discussing	the rising suicide rate among young professionals
controlling idea	the writer's specific stance on the subject; it directs the paragraph	… is a cause for immediate concern
supporting sentence	a sentence in the body that explains, proves or enhances the topic sentence	Second, they produce very few emissions.
concluding sentence	the last sentence; it reminds the reader of the main point in different words	Given the low running costs …
anecdote	a short personal story used to build up to a point	how the writer used to suffer from exam anxiety

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
transition	a connecting word or phrase that shows the relationship between ideas	first, because, however
moreover / nevertheless	transitions for supporting sentences: addition / contrast	from the book's table of transitional words and phrases
all in all / to sum up	transitions for concluding sentences	All in all, given the low running costs ...

Rules and explanations

The three parts of a paragraph

- **Topic sentence:** the main idea plus the writer's attitude or opinion. It relates to the essay's thesis (main point) and tells the reader what the paragraph is about.
- **Body:** usually three to six supporting sentences that explain, prove or enhance the topic sentence.
- **Concluding sentence:** reminds the reader of the main point by restating it in different words.

The book also compares a paragraph to a hamburger: the topic sentence and the concluding sentence are the two similar halves of the bun, and the supporting sentences are the meat.

Main idea and controlling idea

A topic sentence contains a **main idea** (the subject) and a **controlling idea** (the writer's stance). In the book's three examples the main idea is always *marijuana*, but the controlling ideas differ: a destructive influence on teens; a lifeline for cancer patients; a cause of demand for dangerous drugs.

Five characteristics of a good topic sentence

In the lesson material, some of these examples appear above the numbered list; here each is matched to its point.

A good topic sentence ...	Weak example	Stronger example
1. accurately shows what follows	People rarely give firefighters the credit they deserve ... (too general for a paragraph about one incident)	During the October riots, Unit 3B went beyond the call of duty.
2. has a topic and a controlling idea	In this paper, I am going to discuss the rising suicide rate among young professionals.	The rising suicide rate among young professionals is a cause for immediate concern.
3. is clear and easy to follow	a long, confusing sentence about outlines	Most forms of writing can be improved by first creating an outline.
4. does not include supporting details	Salaries should be capped in baseball for many reasons, most importantly so we don't allow the same team to win year after year.	Introducing a salary cap would improve the game of baseball for many reasons.

A good topic sentence ...	Weak example	Stronger example
5. engages the reader with interesting vocabulary	The military deserves better equipment.	The appalling lack of resources provided to the military is outrageous and requires our immediate attention.

Tip from the book: when you write to professors or colleagues, put the topic sentence first (the "top-down" approach), so that busy readers see the main point at once.

Where the topic sentence goes

The lesson material says the topic sentences are "underlined for you", but the underlining may not show in print. Here they are:

Position	Book's paragraph and its topic sentence	When it is used
Beginning (general to specific)	Reality TV: "After reading the new TV guide this week, I had just one thought — we are still being bombarded with reality shows."	The preferred position in academic writing.
End (specific to general)	Animals' senses: "Compared to many animals, our own senses are almost dull." It is also the concluding sentence.	Often in persuasive writing.
Middle	Exam anxiety: "Last year, I was referred to a specialist and finally found a way to control my anxiety — breathing exercises." A personal anecdote comes first.	Often in creative writing. In an essay, check that the paragraph has only one major topic.

Supporting sentences

In the lesson material these five sentences are all labelled "Example". Each shows a different type of support:

Type	Book's example
Reason	The refusal of the baby boom generation to retire is contributing to the current lack of available jobs.
Fact	Many families now rely on older relatives to support them financially.
Statistic	Nearly 10 percent of adults are currently unemployed in the United States.
Quotation	"We will not allow this situation to continue," stated Senator Johns.
Example	Last year, my uncle Bill was asked to retire at the age of fifty-five.

To persuade, rely on facts, statistics and concrete examples rather than personal opinions. Websites ending in .gov or .edu are generally more reliable than others; wikis and blogs are not reliable. For psychology, the free OpenStax textbook *Psychology 2e* is a good place to start.

Concluding sentences

A concluding sentence draws the paragraph together and must not introduce a new idea. In the hybrid car paragraph, the topic sentence says *advantages* and the concluding sentence says *benefits* (a

synonym); it also sums up two advantages: low running costs and environmental benefits. A concluding sentence may (see the childhood obesity examples in the lesson material):

1. restate the main idea;
2. summarize the key points;
3. draw a conclusion based on the information;
4. make a prediction, suggestion or recommendation;
5. offer an additional observation about the controlling idea.

Transitions

The transitions in the hybrid car paragraph (underlined in the book; the underlining may not show in print) are *First*, *Second* and *Because*.

- **Order:** first, second, third, also, furthermore.
- **Consequence:** because, as a result, so that, since, for this reason.
- **Summary**, for the concluding sentence: "**All in all,** given the low running costs ..." The book's table lists more transitions for supporting and concluding sentences.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic prose often links many clauses with "and" (wa). In an English paragraph, divide the ideas into separate sentences and show each relationship with a precise transition (first, because, as a result, however) instead of joining everything with "and".

Practice

Exercise 1. Main idea and controlling idea (first exercise in the lesson material). Circle the main idea and underline the controlling idea in each topic sentence.

1. Exercising three times a week is the only way to maintain good physical health.
2. Sexism and racism are still rampant in today's workplace.
3. Raising the legal driving age to twenty-one would decrease road traffic accidents.
4. Owning a business is the only way to achieve financial success.
5. Dog owners should be prohibited from taking their pets on public beaches.

Exercise 2. Choose the most effective topic sentence from each pair, and say which characteristic decides it.

1. a. This paper will discuss the likelihood of the Democrats winning the next election. b. To boost their chances of winning the next election, the Democrats need to listen to public opinion.
2. a. The unrealistic demands of union workers are crippling the economy for three main reasons. b. Union workers are crippling the economy because companies are unable to remain competitive as a result of added financial pressure.
3. a. Authors are losing money as a result of technological advances. b. The introduction of new technology will devastate the literary world.

4. a. Rap music is produced by untalented individuals with oversized egos. b. This essay will consider whether talent is required in the rap music industry.

Exercise 3. Write topic sentences. Write a topic sentence with a main idea and a controlling idea on each subject.

1. Working while in high school
2. Attending a two-year college
3. The legal drinking age
4. Using public transportation

Exercise 4. Parts of a paragraph. Read the kangaroo rat paragraph ("The desert provides a harsh environment ...") in the lesson material. Number its six sentences. Which is the topic sentence? Which are the supporting sentences? Which is the concluding sentence?

Exercise 5. Concluding sentences. Choose a topic. Write one concluding sentence of each type: restate the main idea; summarize the key points; draw a conclusion; make a prediction, suggestion or recommendation; offer an additional observation.

Speak with your tutor

- "Read only my topic sentence: [paste]. Predict what my paragraph will be about. Then read the whole paragraph and tell me if you were right." (the book's tip)
- "Give me six topic sentences about psychology topics, some weak and some strong. I will say which characteristic each weak one breaks and then improve it."
- "Here is my paragraph: [paste]. Label each sentence as topic, support (reason, fact, statistic, quotation or example) or concluding sentence, and list my transitions."

Read aloud

Pause briefly at each |.

1. There are numerous advantages | to owning a hybrid car.
2. First, | they get 20 percent to 35 percent more miles to the gallon | than a fuel-efficient gas-powered vehicle.
3. Compared to many animals, | our own senses are almost dull.
4. Most forms of writing | can be improved | by first creating an outline.
5. Its ability to adapt to such a hostile environment | makes the kangaroo rat | a truly amazing creature.
6. Word stress: PAR·a·graph, con·TROL·ling, tran·SI·tion, con·CLUD·ing, AN·ec·dote, re·IT·er·ate.

Writing task

Write one paragraph (150 to 200 words) on a topic of your choice (the book's final exercise). Choose a topic that you could develop into your Unit 3 essay: one of the subjects in Exercise 3, or a

psychology topic from PSYC 110, such as how stress affects students' exam performance or why sleep matters for memory.

Required parts: a topic sentence first; three to six supporting sentences with at least three types of support (name the source of any fact or statistic); a concluding sentence of one of the five types; at least three transitions.

Self-editing checklist

- My topic sentence is the first sentence and contains a main idea and a controlling idea.
- It does not announce ("In this paragraph I will ...") and does not contain supporting details.
- Every supporting sentence explains, proves or enhances the controlling idea.
- I used at least three types of support from reliable sources.
- My concluding sentence restates the main point in different words and adds no new idea.
- My transitions show order, consequence or summary correctly.
- I did not join long chains of clauses with "and".

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. Main idea: exercising three times a week. Controlling idea: is the only way to maintain good physical health.
2. Main idea: sexism and racism. Controlling idea: are still rampant in today's workplace.
3. Main idea: raising the legal driving age to twenty-one. Controlling idea: would decrease road traffic accidents.
4. Main idea: owning a business. Controlling idea: is the only way to achieve financial success.
5. Main idea: dog owners. Controlling idea: should be prohibited from taking their pets on public beaches.

Exercise 2

1. b. Sentence a only announces the topic; it has no controlling idea (characteristic 2).
2. a. Sentence b includes a supporting detail (the reason), which belongs in the body (characteristic 4).
3. b. Both have a main idea and a controlling idea, but b engages the reader with a strong verb, *devastate* (characteristic 5). Sentence a is clear but plain.
4. a. Sentence b only announces the topic (characteristic 2). Sentence a takes a clear stance, although its insulting language would weaken an academic essay (see Lesson 22).

Exercise 3 (example answers)

1. Working while in high school teaches teenagers time-management skills that help them in college.
2. Attending a two-year college is a smart financial choice for students who are unsure about their future career.
3. Lowering the legal drinking age would put more young drivers at risk.
4. Using public transportation every day saves commuters money and reduces their stress.

Exercise 4

- Topic sentence: sentence 1 ("The desert provides a harsh environment ..."). Sentence 2 narrows it to the kangaroo rat, so sentences 1 and 2 together are also a correct answer.
- Supporting sentences: 2 to 5 (or 3 to 5). They explain how the kangaroo rat survives: no sweating or panting, specialized kidneys, water from dry seeds.
- Concluding sentence: 6. It repeats the main point in new words: *harsh* becomes *hostile*, *most fascinating* becomes *truly amazing*.

Exercise 5 (example answers; topic: exam stress among university students)

- Restate: Exam stress is a serious problem for many university students.
- Summarize: Lack of sleep, poor time management and fear of failure all add to students' exam stress.

- Conclusion: These findings suggest that exam stress can harm students' grades as well as their health.
- Recommendation: Universities should therefore teach simple coping strategies, such as breathing exercises, early in the first semester.
- Observation: For most students, exam stress is a manageable problem rather than a personal weakness.

My notes